

Digital Ethnographic

We used a combination of digital ethnography and literature review to understand the experiences of left-behind children. Three publicly available YouTube videos were analysed to observe children's lived experiences, while existing academic research was used to provide a broader understanding and compare our observations with previous findings.

Source:

Video 1 - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Nvg0aF4jGgk>

Video 2 - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qLidxfL8q1Q>

Video 3 - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XxZVj78E0EY>

Video	What was observed	Key theme	Initial insight
Video 1: The Left Behind Generation	Parents leave home to find work and provide financial support. Children experience long periods of separation from their parents.	Financial support vs parental presence	Parental migration may improve a family's financial situation, but it can reduce children's access to everyday companionship and parental guidance.
Video 2: Generation Left Behind	Children experience loneliness and emotional difficulties. Some are cared for by grandparents, who provide daily care but may not fully meet emotional support needs.	Emotional support and caregiving	Physical care does not necessarily replace emotional connection. Children may need trusted people and consistent emotional support.

Video 3: Left-behind Girl in China Pleads for Her Parents	A girl expresses that she misses her absent parents. Technology allows communication, but she still wants her parents to be physically present.	Communication and emotional connection	Technology can maintain contact but may not fully replace meaningful emotional connection and parental presence.
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Cross-Video Ethnographic Findings

Emerging finding	Evidence from the videos
Financial support does not replace parental presence	Video 1 shows the trade-off between parents working for income and being physically present with their children.
Emotional support is an important need	Video 2 shows that children may still experience loneliness and emotional difficulties despite receiving basic daily care.
Caregiving arrangements matter	Video 2 suggests that grandparents or relatives may provide physical care, but the type and level of support can differ from parental support.
Communication is not the same as connection	Video 3 suggests that having technology to communicate does not necessarily fulfil a child's need for parental presence and emotional connection.
Experiences are not the same for every child	Across the videos, children's situations appear to differ depending on separation, caregivers and communication.

Literature Findings

The findings from our digital ethnography were also compared with existing academic research. Hong and Fuller (2019) explore the experiences of left-behind children in rural China and provide a broader understanding of how parental migration and separation can shape children's everyday lives. This supports our observations from the videos, particularly the gaps in companionship, emotional support and parental guidance.

Yang (2022) further explores the educational hopes and ambitions of left-behind children in rural China. This provides an additional perspective by showing that left-behind children should not only be understood through the challenges they face, but

also through their educational goals and future aspirations. It also suggests that parental absence may influence the guidance and support available to children as they pursue these goals.

Overall Insight

By comparing our digital ethnography with existing literature, we found that the experiences of left-behind children are complex and cannot be explained by financial difficulty alone. While parental migration may provide financial support for families, parental absence may also affect children's emotional wellbeing, companionship, guidance, education and everyday support.

The videos particularly highlighted emotional connection, caregiving arrangements and communication with absent parents, while the literature provided a broader understanding of children's experiences and educational aspirations. Together, these findings suggest that children's experiences may differ depending on factors such as financial circumstances, caregiving arrangements, length of separation and communication with their parents.

Therefore, our further research will focus on understanding what different left-behind children actually need, rather than assuming that all children experience parental absence in the same way.

References

- Hong, Y., & Fuller, C. (2019). Alone and “left behind”: A case study of “left-behind children” in rural China. *Cogent Education*, 6(1), Article 1654236. <https://doi.org/10.1080/2331186X.2019.1654236>
- Hong, Y. (2022). *The educational hopes and ambitions of left-behind children in rural China: An ethnographic case study*. Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003187264>